Haligric Research Integration Series

Cao Dai

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Great Way of the Third Universal Redemption and the Eye Above the Altar

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In the 1920s, in the French colony of Cochinchina, civil servants gathered around tables to speak with the dead. One night, something answered that was not dead at all.

It called itself Cao Dai, the High Tower, and it said the old religions had been true and had fallen out of reach of one another, and that God would now speak without prophets.

Within a generation its followers had built a cathedral of dragons and pastel towers, raised an army, and named a French novelist as their envoy to the world.

A single left eye watches from the altar. A hundred years on, the faith it founded is still arguing over who holds the keys to its house.

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Introduction — The Eye Above the Altar

Cao Dai is a monotheistic religion founded in southern Vietnam in 1926. Its full name is Dai Dao Tam Ky Pho Do, the Great Way of the Third Universal Redemption. Cao Dai literally means High Tower or High Palace, the place from which God reigns, and it is used as a name for God himself. The religion draws deliberately on Buddhism, Taoism, Confucianism, Christianity, and Vietnamese ancestor veneration, and it holds that all of them flowed from one source and were scattered because earlier revelations came through fallible human messengers.

Its claim about how God now speaks is the reason it exists. In the two earlier eras of salvation, God is said to have worked through prophets. In this third era, God is said to have spoken directly, through spirit mediums, without a human intermediary. So Cao Dai may be the only sizable religion on earth whose founding scriptures came through séance, and its government structure was dictated the same way.

Follower numbers vary widely by source, and that is a story in itself. The Vietnamese state's religion figures reported about 2.4 million adherents in 2024, placing Cao Dai fourth among Vietnam's sixteen recognized religions. Other reports give more than 1.1 million for the main Tay Ninh church, older government figures run to several million, and some estimates reach higher. Diaspora communities number in the tens of thousands.

This document was commissioned after Cao Dai surfaced in a video survey of world religions, and no earlier document in this library covers it. It treats the faith on its own terms, separates what is documented from what is popularly repeated, and gives real weight to the serious present-day dispute over the religion's control.

Origins — Séance in Colonial Saigon

French Indochina in the early twentieth century was a place where Vietnamese clerks, teachers, and officials read French literature, worked for a colonial state, and still kept ancestor altars at home. Table-tapping and spirit writing, popular in France since the mid-nineteenth century, joined older Chinese and Vietnamese forms of spirit-writing with a planchette or winnowing basket. Jeremy Jammes and Shao Zhu Shuai point to a specific channel: the five Minh societies of Cochinchina, spirit-writing groups tied to the Chinese Way of Former Heaven, of which Minh Su was the largest and oldest. They report that all of Cao Dai's first members were connected to or came out of these associations, and that Cao Dai adopted their cosmology, theology, and expectation of Maitreya and adapted them to its own hierarchy. The two traditions met naturally among educated colonial employees. Victor Hugo's Jersey séance transcripts, published in 1925 as Les Tables Tournantes de Jersey, reached French Indochina that same year.

Ngo Van Chieu, born in 1878, was a Vietnamese official in the colonial administration who began participating in séances around 1919. He reported messages from a spirit that identified itself as Cao Dai. Assigned to Phu Quoc Island, he reported in 1920 a vision of a great eye. He began worshipping God through that symbol and is honored as the first disciple.

In 1925 a separate group in Saigon, Cao Quynh Cu, Cao Hoai Sang, and Pham Cong Tac, took up table-tapping. A spirit signing itself AAA began communicating with them. The church's history says that on Christmas Eve 1925 it revealed itself to be the Supreme Being, Cao Dai, and it directed them to Ngo Van Chieu. Le Van Trung, a former government official and member of the colonial council, joined them and was transformed by the experience, giving up opium and his former way of life.

In 1926 the group signed a formal declaration founding the religion and presented it to the French colonial authorities, dated in the church's own history to September 28, though other accounts give October 7. The surviving text, addressed to Governor Le Fol of Cochinchina, carries 28 signatures from a landowner, a former councillor, Buddhist monks,

officials, and teachers, and announces a single faith reorganizing Buddhism, Taoism, and Confucianism. The public inauguration took place in November 1926 at Tu Lam Pagoda, Go Ken, in Tay Ninh province, on the fifteenth day of the tenth lunar month. Some sources give slightly different Western calendar dates for this event. Accounts claim that very large numbers joined within months, and by 1934 one count gives over 300,000 adherents and 128 chapels, with the religion passing a million by about 1940.

The Founders — Chieu, Trung, and Tac

Ngo Van Chieu, the first disciple, was offered the role of first Pope and declined. He withdrew from the public movement, did not sign the 1926 founding declaration, and rejected the pronouncements of the Tay Ninh séances, choosing a quieter esoteric practice. His followers became the Chieu Minh branch. He died on April 18, 1932.

Le Van Trung, who lived from 1876 to 1934, took up the leadership and is recorded as Giao Tong, Pope, though with the title of Acting Pope. No full living human Pope has been ordained in the sense the Constitution describes. The Spiritual Pope is the Chinese poet Li Bai, whom Caodaists call Ly Thai Bach, and who is believed to hold the office from the spirit world. Sources in the tradition and tourism writing sometimes call Pham Cong Tac the Pope, which is loose usage.

Pham Cong Tac, born June 21, 1890, was a customs clerk who became Ho Phap, the Defender of the Dharma and head of the religion's legislative and mediumistic branch. After Le Van Trung's death he became the leading authority of the Tay Ninh church, and he guided it through the most dangerous decades of its existence. He died in exile in Cambodia in 1959.

Key Texts and the Religious Constitution

Most of Cao Dai's official scripture was received through séance between 1925 and 1929. The Thanh Ngon Hiep Tuyen, or Compilation of Divine Messages, collects these communications. The Phap Chanh Truyen is the Religious Constitution, setting out the entire hierarchy as received from God. The Tan Luat, the New Code, is the working rulebook for ordinary life, drafted by the early leadership and covering initiation, diet, marriage, and discipline. In 1948 Pham Cong Tac gave a series of sermons inviting followers on a journey through the heavens to see how souls are saved. Christopher Hartney translated 35 of them in How Heaven Works, published by Brill in 2024, and reads them as a collective shamanic journey.

Most of the scriptures are in Vietnamese, and the communications themselves were recorded in Vietnamese, Chinese, French, and even English. Prayer books set out the daily liturgy as well as funeral prayers such as the Kinh Cau Hon and the Di Lac Chon Kinh, the True Scripture of Maitreya. The Tay Ninh Holy See regards itself as the source of orthodox scripture, and has claimed that sole role since 1927. Groups that broke away have their own séance-derived writings that Tay Ninh does not accept.

God and the Divine Mother — Wider Cosmology

Caodaist cosmology begins with the Tao of Chinese philosophy, the nameless and eternal source. From it a cosmic event gave rise to God, who governs yang, and God then produced the Goddess, the master of yin. From yin and yang together the universe formed. This makes the Cao Dai God both supreme and, unusually for a monotheism, not quite the first thing.

God bears many titles, among them Ngoc Hoang Thuong De, the Jade Emperor, and Cao Dai Tien Ong Dai Bo Tat Ma Ha Tat, a title that packs Confucian, Taoist, and Buddhist honorifics into one name. Caodaists teach that the Jade Emperor, Yahweh, and Allah are names for

one God. Cao Dai's own short description of him says the mind is God, and that the eyes are the master of the mind.

The Divine Mother, Duc Phat Mau, also called Dieu Tri Kim Mau, the Golden Mother of the Jasper Pond, is venerated as Mother of the Universe. She governs yin and is said to provide the subtle body, or peri-spirit, of living beings, and she is assisted by the Nine Goddesses, or Nine Female Buddhas. She has her own temples and her own great festival. For a religion headed by male ranks, her presence gives Cao Dai a strongly felt maternal center, which followers describe as the love of a mother for scattered children.

Souls are said to pass through many incarnations, climbing the ladder of existence toward reunion with God. Good deeds create merit, and bad deeds create karma that must be worked out. The aim is to end the cycle of rebirth and return to the source. Caodaists describe the heavens as many levels populated by Buddhas, Immortals, Saints, and Genii, and they regard the spirit world as active in human affairs, which is why communication with it was thought possible at all.

The Three Eras of Salvation

Caodaist history is divided into three great amnesties, or periods of salvation. In the First, God is said to have worked through Dipankara Buddha, the Taoist patriarch Thai Thuong Dao To, King Fuxi of Chinese tradition, and Moses. In the Second, through Shakyamuni Buddha, Laozi, Confucius, and Jesus, and in some accounts Muhammad. Each revelation was true, but it was suited to its time and place and carried through human vessels, and so it was corrupted or narrowed.

The Third is now. In this era God is said to have made a final, universal offer of salvation to humanity directly, and the term amnesty matters. In Caodaist teaching this is a general pardon: souls of any background may be redeemed if they sincerely turn toward God. The Tay Ninh tradition says this era will run for 700,000 years. Modern travel accounts summarize Cao Dai as a blend, but Caodaists would resist that word. They understand themselves as a reunification of an original Way that was always one.

Punishment after death exists in the liturgy but is not eternal. The Repentance Prayer names the underworld courts of Yama and warns of rebirth as a horse, buffalo, or dog. Messages attributed to the Seventh and Eighth Female Buddhas describe Am Quang as a dim halfway station between heaven and earth, where souls review their past lives, sometimes for very long periods, helped by Ksitigarbha, and teach that repentance, a vegetarian diet, and prayer in this life can spare a soul from it. The era has an end point. Caodaists expect the Hoi Long Hoa, the Dragon Flower Assembly, a final examination of life on earth presided over by Maitreya, the future Buddha. Souls are judged by how they lived their secular and spiritual lives, and Maitreya selects the virtuous to rebuild the world in an age of peace. The statue of Maitreya riding a tiger on the Hiep Thien Dai points to this role, the tiger marking 1926, the founding year. Their watchword captures it. The aim is Tam Giao Quy Nguyen, Ngu Chi Phuc Nhat: the Three Teachings return to their origin, and the Five Branches unite as one.

The Three Teachings and Five Branches

The Three Teachings are Buddhism, Taoism, and Confucianism, represented across Cao Dai banners and robes: yellow for Buddhism, blue for Taoism, and red for Confucianism. The colors signal virtue in Buddhism, tolerance in Taoism, and authority in Confucianism, according to common explanations, and clergy of the three branches wear them in temple.

The Five Branches describe a ladder of spiritual attainment rather than a list of denominations: Nhon Dao, the way of humanity, centered on human duties; Than Dao, the way of the genii or spirits; Thanh Dao, the way of the saints, associated with Christianity in Caodaist explanation; Tien Dao, the way of the immortals, associated with Taoism; and Phat

Dao, the way of the Buddhas. A person is to begin with being a decent human being and move upward by way of service, self-cultivation, and meditation.

The temple's own emblem compresses all of this. Three objects, each a sign of one teaching, are displayed together: the alms bowl of Buddhism, the feather duster of Taoism, and the Spring and Autumn Annals of Confucianism.

The Divine Eye

Cao Dai's central symbol is the Thien Nhan, the Divine Eye: a single left eye, usually within a triangle or on a globe, surrounded by rays. It stands in place of any image of God. Temples show it on the altar, on the facade, in windows, and on banners. The Holy See has about fifty instances, and local temple eyes commonly carry sixteen rays.

It is the left eye because yang is associated with the left, and God is the master of yang. The Tay Ninh Holy See sets a large star-covered blue globe at the center of the sanctuary, about 3.3 meters across, with the Eye upon it. The teaching attached to the symbol is direct: the eyes are the master of the mind, the mind is God, and God is the Self. In other words, the Eye that watches is inside the watcher as well.

Outsiders often connect it with the Masonic Eye of Providence or the eye on the back of the American dollar bill. The visual resemblance is real, and Caodaism emerged in a colonial world where Freemasonry and Spiritism both circulated, but no source reviewed here documents a direct connection, and Caodaists trace it to Ngo Van Chieu's own vision.

The Three Saints and the Spirit Messengers

A famous mural at the entrance of the Holy See shows the Three Saints signing a covenant between God and humanity: the Chinese revolutionary Sun Yat-sen, the French author Victor Hugo, and the Vietnamese poet and prophet Nguyen Binh Khiem, known as Trang Trinh. Hugo writes the words Dieu et Humanite, Amour et Justice, God and Humanity, Love and Justice. They are not worshipped. They are prophets of the third era.

Hugo's presence has an exact historical trail. During his exile on Jersey in 1853, after the death of his daughter Leopoldine, he conducted table-tapping séances. When those transcripts reached French Indochina in 1925, the circumstances could hardly have been more apt for Caodaists. Around 1927 Pham Cong Tac, in Cambodia, began receiving messages attributed to Hugo, who came to be considered the head of the foreign mission, and by 1949 Tac had declared Hugo a reincarnation of the Vietnamese poet Nguyen Du.

Above the three stands the Three Religions' representative trio: Quan Am for the Buddhas, Ly Thai Bach for the Immortals, and Quan Thanh, the Chinese war god Guan Yu, for the Saints. Their presence in the daily prayer is standard across Tay Ninh practice.

A correction is due here, because popular accounts blur two different things. The video that prompted this document calls Victor Hugo, Winston Churchill, William Shakespeare, Sun Yat-sen, and Louis Pasteur official saints. The formal group of Three Saints is Hugo, Sun Yat-sen, and Trang Trinh. Separately, over seventy spirits were reported as communicating with early Caodaist groups, and the Western names among them include Joan of Arc, La Fontaine, Shakespeare, Tolstoy, Descartes, Pasteur, Marcus Aurelius, Clemenceau, and the French statesman Aristide Briand, and one account adds Lenin. So Shakespeare and Pasteur did appear in the séance record, as communicating spirits, but not as holders of a fixed rank alongside Jesus and the Buddha. Churchill did not appear in any Cao Dai source reviewed for this document, and his name should be treated as unverified.

Spirit Writing — The Séance and Its Ban

Cao Dai's founding method was the séance, and several forms were used, drawing openly on French Spiritism. Early leaders read Allan Kardec, Camille Flammarion, and Victor

Hugo, and a 1926 message described Kardec and Flammarion as forerunners sent to humanity, the way Elijah and John the Baptist were sent. A French spiritist writer, Gabriel Gobron, became the religion's first Western historian and represented it at spiritualist congresses in Barcelona in 1934 and Glasgow in 1937. Early sessions used table-tapping. The Tay Ninh church adopted the ngoc co, a basket with a beak that holds a writing tool, steadied by two mediums and moved across a surface, a form that descends from Chinese spirit-writing. A formal séance had at least five participants: a leader, two mediums, an interpreter, and a secretary. Other methods included writing directly with a brush, and leaving blank paper sealed in an envelope above the altar to be opened later. Messages were delivered in Vietnamese, Chinese, French, and English.

The Hiep Thien Dai, the Palace of Union with Heaven, was established precisely to manage this channel. The Tay Ninh Holy See insisted that only it could conduct official séances, partly because rival mediums kept producing rival revelations. Séances were, in effect, both the religion's strength and its largest source of schism.

After 1975 the communist government banned séances. Sources state that they have been prohibited since then, and many Caodaist leaders now say spirit writing is no longer necessary, teaching that people can commune with God by looking inward. So a religion founded on direct dictation from heaven has gone for fifty years without using its main instrument of revelation at its principal seat. In Cao Dai, the question of how to govern without new messages from God has become a very practical one.

Organization — Three Palaces of Authority

Cao Dai's constitution describes three bodies. The Bat Quai Dai, the Eight Trigrams Palace, is the invisible body of God and the divine beings, the soul of the religion. The Hiep Thien Dai, the Palace of Union with Heaven, is the legislative and judicial branch, led by the Ho Phap, with the Thuong Pham and Thuong Sanh overseeing religious and secular affairs, and it receives communications from heaven. The Cuu Trung Dai, the Palace of Nine Spheres, is the executive body, led by the Giao Tong and responsible for administration and mission. In 1938 a charitable body, Phuoc Thien, was added under the Hiep Thien Dai.

The executive ranks resemble those of the Catholic Church, and the resemblance is deliberate: one Giao Tong, three Chuong Phap, three Dau Su, thirty-six Phoi Su, seventy-two Giao Su, three thousand Giao Huu, and an unlimited number of Le Sanh or student priests, minor officers, and adepts. There is a direct French influence in this picture, as the system mirrors both a Catholic hierarchy and a republican separation of powers. Each rank is, according to the code, filled by a vote of those beneath or beside it.

Women have their own College and may be ordained, in a structure parallel to the men's, with a key limit. Women can rise as high as Dau Su, or Cardinal, and no higher. The Holy See's explanation is that God's nature is yang, and yin cannot rule over yang without producing disorder. Caodaists often describe the faith as more egalitarian than others of its era, and in some ways it was, since it ordained women from the start. Lady Cardinal Huong Hieu, who lived from 1887 to 1971, led the Female Dignitary College through decades of colonial suspicion, and Archbishop Huong Nuong, who lived from 1910 to 1985, gave more than fifty years to charitable work and advocacy for religious freedom.

The Holy See at Tay Ninh

The Holy See stands about five kilometers from Tay Ninh city and about ninety kilometers from Ho Chi Minh City, at the center of a grounds complex of more than a square kilometer, near the sacred mountain Nui Ba Den. Followers acquired the land in the late 1920s. Dates for the building vary by source. One detailed account gives groundbreaking in 1931, serious construction from 1936, and completion in 1947, another gives 1927 to 1953, and the great inauguration is commonly put in 1955. The work was done without Western engineers, largely by unpaid followers.

The building is about 97.5 meters long and 22 wide, with twin front towers rising 27 meters, and it mixes the shape of a Gothic cathedral with the colors of a Vietnamese pagoda. Inside, the nave rises through nine levels matching the nine ranks of the hierarchy, and twenty-eight dragon-wrapped pink pillars run its length. At the far end, the octagonal Bat Quai Dai rises over a twelve-tiered platform, holding the great globe with the Divine Eye. Above the globe stand small figures of religious leaders in tiers, including the Buddha, Laozi, Confucius, Li Bai, and Jesus, and cardinals are entombed behind it. A smaller temple is dedicated to the Divine Mother. A visitor in 2024 timed a service at about thirty minutes, ending with a gong. Above the worshippers is a sky of painted stars and clouds.

Visitors at noon may watch from the upper balcony, and travelers have made it one of the most visited sites in southern Vietnam. That brings its own frictions, since this is a working sanctuary. Men enter on the right and women on the left, and shoes are removed before entering.

The Four Daily Offerings — Step by Step

Caodaists observe four daily times of worship: 6 a.m., noon, 6 p.m., and midnight. The times, called Thoi, correspond to the four quarter-turns of the day, and followers are encouraged to attend or to perform at least one at home. In the temple, Tay Ninh's ritual follows this pattern.

Step one: a bell rings to mark the approach of the service, and worshippers gather. Laypeople wear white, and clergy wear the yellow, blue, or red of their branches. Men and women enter by separate doors and line up in rows facing the altar. Step two: the offerings are set. Wine and tea alternate by hour: wine at the hours of the rat and horse, around midnight and noon, and tea at the hours of the cat and rooster, around 6 a.m. and 6 p.m. Five sticks of incense are lit, in two rows, three nearer the Eye and two farther away.

Step three: a small orchestra of traditional instruments plays from above while a choir chants the prayers. Step four: the congregation prays and prostrates in unison, following the formula described below. Step five: the concluding bell sounds and the worshippers bow. On major occasions, the first and fifteenth of the lunar month and anniversaries, the Drum of Thunder and the Great Jade Bell are played in three divisions of twelve parts each, with twelve strokes each, and the flowers, wine, and tea are offered together.

The Home Altar and Prostrations — Step by Step

The home altar is the anchor of ordinary Caodaist practice, and the tradition gives exact instructions. It goes in a pure place in the middle of the home, high on the wall, with a curtain that can be drawn across it. It holds a representation of the Divine Eye, a lamp for the Universal Monad, fruit, flowers, tea on the right for yin, three glasses of wine, pure water on the left for yang, two candles, and an incense burner.

The three offerings carry the religion's inner teaching. Flowers stand for tinh, the body or essence. Wine stands for khi, vital energy. Tea stands for than, the spirit. Caodaists call these the Three Treasures. To place them on an altar is to offer yourself, and cultivating them within is what the tradition's esoteric practice works upon.

The hand position, An Ty, is unusual. Step one: with the left hand, touch the thumb to the base of the ring finger, then close the fingers over it. Step two: wrap the right hand around the left, with the right thumb between the left thumb and index finger. Step three: hold the joined hands before the body and raise them to the forehead.

Step four: bow deeply three times, then kneel. Step five: bring the hands to the forehead and recite quietly, moving them to the left shoulder, the right shoulder, and the chest, with invocations of the Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha, and of God, Quan Am, Ly Thai Bach, Quan Thanh, and all Buddhas, Immortals, Saints, and Spirits. Step six: perform the prostrations with hands flat on the ground, fingers spread and thumbs crossing. Before God, each

prostration has four slow nods to the ground, twelve in all. Before Buddhas and Immortals, each has three, nine in all. Before the Divine Mother the shoulder movements and the Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha formula are left out, and the worshipper makes three prostrations of three nods each. At home a gong is struck three times before and three times after worship.

Initiation — Step by Step

Step one: two followers of good moral standing introduce the candidate to the head of the parish or local congregation, and they act as sponsors in the path of ethics. Step two: the candidate studies, learning the prayers by heart and getting to know the Religious Code. Step three: at the temple, the candidate kneels before God's altar with a dignitary presiding.

Step four: the candidate takes a solemn vow to know only the one Cao Dai religion, never to change their mind, to live in harmony with the community, and to obey the laws of the faith. The traditional vow invokes a severe heavenly penalty for breaking it. Step five: the candidate receives a temporary religious certificate, and the local temple registers them. Step six: for a six-month probation, the new disciple memorizes the verse prayers, learns the rituals, keeps at least six vegetarian days per month, and studies God's teachings. Step seven: after showing they can meet the obligations, the disciple receives a permanent certificate.

The home is blessed as part of the same process. The parish head or a representative blesses the house and installs God's altar. The ceremony implies repentance for past wrongs and is described as joining one family regardless of race, nationality, or language. Fellow followers are addressed as brothers and sisters from then on.

The Precepts and the Great Rules

Cao Dai's ethics rest on the Five Prohibitions, which closely track Buddhist lay precepts. Do not kill. Do not steal, which includes cheating and taking the property of others. Do not commit lewd acts, which covers adultery and immoral conduct. Do not indulge in alcohol or luxury, which includes excessive eating and drinking. Do not lie, which covers slander, cursing, blasphemy, and breaking promises.

Four Great Commandments address how people behave in a community. Obey the teachings of those in higher ranks, with humility, and stay open to advice. Do not flaunt your talents, and serve others without pride. Be exact in money matters, keep clear accounts, and show courtesy between ranks. Be sincere, consistent whether anyone is watching or not, and be reconciled to one another. The third of these is unusually practical for a religion's top rules, and it reads like what it is: guidance written by former civil servants.

The Secular Rules govern daily life in detail. Believers may not work in occupations involving the killing of animals, obscene publishing, or selling alcohol or opium. Dress should be simple cotton, avoiding silk. Spouses should be co-religionists unless the future spouse converts, and the wedding is announced at the temple eight days ahead. Concubinage is forbidden, widow remarriage is allowed, and divorce is limited to adultery or a lack of filial piety. One rule permits a second wife in the specific case of a childless first wife, and it is a rule the modern reader should note as a product of its time.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Vegetarianism is Cao Dai's most visible daily discipline, and it is arranged as a graded path. Followers begin with six days each lunar month, on the 1st, 8th, 14th, 15th, 23rd, and 30th, and work up to ten days, and full-time vegetarianism is the ideal for higher adepts and anyone seeking clergy rank. The practice is understood to purify body and spirit and to

reduce harm to living beings. Food at Cao Dai temples is known for being delicious. The Hanoi congregation serves free vegetarian bun rieu on the first day of each lunar month.

The tradition divides its path in two. Exoterism is for laypeople living family lives: prayer, ethics, ancestor veneration, and service. Esoterism, Noi Giao Tam Phap, is for those who have completed the Three Deeds of merit, the Tam Cong, or Triple Fold Path, of service, self-cultivation, and meditation. Tay Ninh's own sequence has three stages. First comes service to the religion. Then comes Tam Lap, the three duties of serving the world through deeds, words, and virtue. Only then comes tu chon, inner cultivation. Pham Cong Tac's 1947 meditation instructions ask the practitioner to be tolerant, cheerful, and guided by conscience, to overcome hatred and selfishness with kindness, to eat pure food, and to think pure thoughts. He calls choosing right over wrong the Magic Sword of Wisdom, and the stated goal is to open the door to the Eight Trigrams Palace in this life. They may be admitted to a Tinh That, a Meditation House. Admission requires at least six months of full vegetarianism, and residents give up tobacco and betel, eat only scheduled meals, keep quiet, and have no outside contact without permission. The inner work transforms tinh, khi, and than, the same three treasures offered on the altar, in an alchemy inherited from Taoist internal cultivation.

For ordinary followers the wellness logic is modest and communal: four pauses in the day, a home with a calm altar, regular meatless days, neighbors in white on the first and fifteenth of the month. Service is treated as the most reliable way to earn merit, and caring for orphans, the elderly, and the sick is formally part of the path through Phuoc Thien. Prayer is recommended with a silent mind, which brings a contemplative dimension to the most ordinary chant.

Funerals and Memorial Rites — Step by Step

Cao Dai funerals are among the most detailed parts of its ritual system. Step one: when a person is dying, a prayer ceremony is held to the Divine Master. The leader stands at the head of the person and calls to them, urging them to rise toward paradise, and the Kinh Cau Hon is chanted three times. Step two: after the last breath the Kinh Khi Da Chet Roi is chanted three times. Step three: before the body goes into the coffin, a ceremony is held and the Kinh Tan Liem is chanted, and the chief mourner prostrates before the soul.

Step four: for those eligible, the Mystery of Deliverance, Phep Xac, is performed with chanting. This rite, said to release the soul from the body, is reserved for those who have kept ten or more vegetarian days per month and have lived by the rules. Step five: the procession moves in strict order: the banner of the Third Universal Amnesty, a rank banner, the altar of the deceased, a choir in two lines with men left and women right, the coffin, the chief mourners, then women and men. Step six: at the grave, the Kinh Ha Huyet and Vang Sanh Than Chu are each chanted three times, and the Divine Master's name is invoked three times.

Step seven: mourning continues on a schedule. Nine nine-day periods, the Lam Tuan Cuu, are each marked by a minor ceremony in which the three treasures are offered, with the Di Lac Chon Kinh chanted. The soul is said to climb one level of heaven with each. Step eight: the Tieu Tuong follows two hundred days after the ninth period, and the Dai Tuong three hundred days after that, ending the mourning in the Confucian manner. Scholar Zhushuai Shao, in a 2021 Paris Cite doctoral thesis, argues that these rites are a large part of why the religion survives. After suppression, funeral, mourning, and healing services gave a marginal community a space of its own under strong state control, and the people needed to carry out each death keep the community alive. Family members, even those outside the religion, can have prayers read, and the household keeps a vegetarian diet as long as the coffin remains in the home.

Festivals and the Hundred-Year Mark

Monthly rites take place at midnight on the 1st and 15th of the lunar month. The most important annual festival is the Hoi Yen Dieu Tri Cung, the Banquet of the Jasper Pond Palace, honoring the Divine Mother and the Nine Goddesses, on the fifteenth of the eighth lunar month, the same date as Vietnam's Mid-Autumn Festival. The anniversary of the founding falls on the fifteenth of the tenth lunar month. Early in the year, around the eighth and ninth of the first lunar month, the Duc Chi Ton festival honors the Supreme Being as Great Father. In Tay Ninh it features a dance of the half-horse, half-dragon Long Ma and the Four Holy Beasts, and prayers for good weather, harvests, and peace. The Hoi Yen climax comes late. After three days of formal worship at set hours, with a midnight offering in the inner court and a noon ceremony at the Divine Mother's altar, a gong sounds at 10 p.m. on the full moon night at the Bao An Tu, the Holy Mother and the Nine Goddesses are welcomed, and dignitaries offer hymns and spiritual poetry while worshippers outside sit in silence, palms together, facing the inner sanctuary.

Cao Dai's own count of its centennial occasions has a complexity of its own. On the evening of November 14, 2024, the Holy See held a ceremony reported as the hundredth anniversary of the opening of the Great Way, attended by about 50,000 people, with a procession of the Divine Eye flag, a 20-meter dragon, and government officials present. Reports note the religion dates its formal founding to 1926, so the count evidently starts earlier, or rests on the tradition's own dating. The same report gave about 2.4 million adherents nationally, with over one million in Tay Ninh's own church.

In October 2025 a separate 100th founding anniversary was marked in Ho Chi Minh City at the Nam Thanh oratory, regarded as the religion's birthplace. USCIRF, counting from the 1926 inauguration, places the centennial in 2026. On October 6, 2025, the 100th Hoi Yen Dieu Tri Cung drew over 100,000 people that evening, and more than 200,000 over two days by the Holy See's estimate. At 6 p.m. dignitaries and followers performed the ritual in white ao dai, and men wore black turbans. A flower float bearing the Divine Mother and Nine Goddesses moved down a 400-meter route, followed by two incense dragons 39 meters long, each worked by more than fifty people, a form reported as unique to Tay Ninh.

War, Armies, and Exile

Few religions founded in the twentieth century have a military history as tangled as this one. Cao Dai grew in a country under French rule, and by the 1930s its leaders criticized the French while keeping working relations with them. Its rapid growth worried colonial officials. In September 1941 the French occupied Tay Ninh and exiled Pham Cong Tac and at least four other dignitaries to Madagascar.

With its leader gone, the movement turned to Japan. General Tran Quang Vinh founded the Cao Dai armed forces, and by 1943, with the help of the Japanese military police, clandestine paramilitary groups were forming, about 3,000 men strong. They assisted the Japanese takeover in March 1945. After Japan's defeat the Viet Minh attacked Caodaists as well, and in June 1946 Vinh made a truce with the French, who brought Tac back from exile. The Cao Dai forces became French auxiliaries, and at their peak claims reached over 20,000 troops, while Tay Ninh province became in practice a small religious state.

In 1954 Tac went to the Geneva talks as an adviser and tried to prevent the partition of Vietnam. He failed. Under the new South Vietnamese president Ngo Dinh Diem, the sects' independence came to an end. General Nguyen Thanh Phuong, reportedly after receiving a large payment, brought his Cao Dai troops over to Diem's army. General Trinh Minh The was shot dead in May 1955, in a killing never solved. In October 1955 Phuong's forces disarmed the Papal Guard at Tay Ninh and deposed Tac, and in February 1956 Tac fled to Cambodia. He died there in 1959.

Tran My-Van, writing in 1996, called this an asymmetric relationship. Caodaists stayed pro-Japanese through the occupation because they judged it could advance independence from France, and the collaboration damaged their standing once the war ended.

The record defies easy framing. A faith teaching nonviolence and vegetarianism fielded an army, and that army served Japan, then France, then a South Vietnamese state. Members also fought against the French and against Diem at various moments. Caodaists explain it as survival in a war with no safe sides, and critics call it a failure of the faith's own first precept. Both are true to some degree.

After 1975 — State Control and Recognition

When Saigon fell in April 1975, the new communist government treated Cao Dai with suspicion because of its political history. Séances were banned, the governing bodies were effectively dissolved, and church property was seized. Some leaders were detained, and refugees began to leave. In the 1990s the state's policy began to shift. According to several accounts, legal recognition and permission for regulated practice came in 1997, when the government recognized a new management structure for the Tay Ninh Holy See.

Today the state's list includes Cao Dai among the sixteen religions it formally recognizes, with one report counting ten recognized denominations, one monastic sect, and several independent establishments, along with about 10,000 clergy, 30,000 lay officers, and over 1,300 places of worship. In one sense, this is a substantial revival. In another, it is the source of the most serious dispute in the religion's history, discussed under controversies below.

Schisms and Branches

A faith built on séance tends to divide whenever a new medium arrives. Between 1934 and 1975 Cao Dai split into as many as thirty groups. As of 2014, eleven held legal recognition. The earliest divide is Chieu Minh, the esoteric, non-institutional line of Ngo Van Chieu. Ban Chinh Dao, which split from Tay Ninh under Nguyen Ngoc Tuong and Le Ba Trang in the mid-1930s and based itself in Ben Tre, became a major rival. Tien Thien formed around 1930 in My Tho, Chon Ly in the same area, and Minh Chon was declared in Bac Lieu in 1934. Cao Trieu Phat, a leader in that Mekong Delta branch, later served in Vietnam's first National Assembly. Central Vietnam developed its own missionary body in Da Nang from 1938.

Efforts to reunite the sects have been made repeatedly, including an association in 1936, a united holy society from 1947 to 1954, and alliances of five sects in 1955 and eighteen in 1972. The historic split between Tay Ninh's institutional church and Chieu Minh's inner path remains a useful key: one half of the tradition builds a visible church on earth, and the other half sits quietly and turns inward.

Legacy and Influence — The Diaspora

Cao Dai arrived in Cambodia early. Pham Cong Tac established missions in Phnom Penh after his 1927 transfer. The Kim Bien Temple was inaugurated on May 22, 1937, forced to relocate in 1955, and rebuilt by 1962. The Phnom Penh Post later reported a dispute over it. A Vietnamese-American group funded restoration and gave a statue of Pham Cong Tac, in place since 2015. Followers say the Tay Ninh side took control in 2004, and the statue was removed at the head cleric's request after a Tay Ninh delegation met local officials. The remaining congregation was reported at about 30 or 40. Counts for Cambodia vary, from about 2,000 Caodaists to a 2011 field estimate of 400 to 500 active adherents, most of Vietnamese descent or from Khmer convert families. The 2011 report found the Phnom Penh temples providing free burial for anyone, regardless of religion, collecting the dead in their own vehicle, on the belief that proper burial helps them move on. The newest congregation on record is in Taiwan. Tuan Em Nguyen reported in 2022 that Vietnamese

immigrants founded a small group in Zhongli, Taoyuan, with approval from senior leaders in Vietnam, and that members see the spread there as long foretold.

After 1975 Vietnamese refugees carried the religion to the United States, Australia, France, and Canada, with California holding about 90 percent of the American community. Temples opened in San Jose, Sacramento, San Diego, Anaheim, Pomona, and elsewhere. The first California temple, Thien Ly Buu Toa in San Jose, was founded by a female medium, Bach Dieu Hoa. In New Orleans, five members founded a temple in 1986, and followers later built a larger Vietnamese-style temple largely by themselves on weekends and holidays, with beginners keeping six vegetarian days per month and regular members ten. Texas has its own communities, with temples reported in Dallas, Houston, and San Antonio, and a Dallas Observer report described two Dallas congregations that had divided partly over charity work. Diaspora estimates run from about 13,000 to 30,000.

Beyond its numbers, Cao Dai is one of the clearest case studies in how colonial encounter can produce new religion. It emerged from Vietnamese ancestral practice, Chinese spirit-writing, French Spiritism, and Catholic organization, and turned the colonizer's own Victor Hugo into an envoy from a Vietnamese God. Anthropologist Janet Alison Hoskins, in The Divine Eye and the Diaspora (2015), is among the scholars who have read it as a Vietnamese response to colonial rule as much as a blending of religions. It stands as one of the great indigenous religious creations of modern Asia.

Controversies and Fairness

The most serious current issue is control of the religion's own home. In the view of independent Caodaists and human rights groups, the Vietnamese state dissolved the Sacerdotal Council in the early 1980s and in 1997 created a state-managed body, which they call the 1997 Sect, that now occupies the Tay Ninh Holy See. A January 31, 2024 joint letter signed by ten organizations and fourteen individuals, including Boat People SOS, CSW, and Cao Dai Today, says about 300 local temples were taken, sometimes by force with police support, and lists beatings, disruption of services, grave demolition, and blocked funerals. The letter cites a 2018 USCIRF report describing the seizure of all but about fifteen of more than three hundred temples. Its 2025 report says police and members of the state-controlled sect harassed independent followers, blocked temple visits and funerals, and that in May police questioned Tran Van Duc after he met American consular staff. USCIRF's December 2025 country update says independent followers are still seeking access to sites seized in 1997, including the Holy See, and that they face travel bans. It cites the state-approved centennial as an example of the government showcasing religion on its own terms. The pressure has continued: On May 12, 2026, police in Dong Thap Province arrested four Cao Dai clergy and lay leaders, Tran Ngoc Suong, Nguyen Ngoc Dien, Nguyen Anh Phung, and Tran Thanh Tuyet, over interviews and online material about human rights abuses. CSW reports that Phung and Tuyet were released the next day and that Suong was charged under Article 117 and held in pre-trial detention. The Vietnamese Magazine's later bulletin says he is free on bail. Independent followers also go to court. In September 2024 Le Van Mot, of the independent Cao Dai Chon Truyen 1926 group, sued city officials in Tan An, Long An Province, over the revocation of his business license, which the same magazine says was revoked because of his religion. Vietnam's amended Law on Belief and Religion, passed on April 23, 2026, takes effect on January 1, 2027.

USCIRF's 2026 Vietnam brief lists Cao Dai followers among the unregistered groups reporting threats, harassment, and detention, and finds conditions worsening. Vietnam's National Assembly passed amendments to its religion law in April 2026, effective January 2027, with broadly worded prohibited acts and registration decisions left to local administrators. The same brief notes some positive changes, including religious materials for prisoners, and a reaffirmed right to freedom of belief. Human Rights Watch's World Report 2026 adds that security agents stopped Cao Dai activist Hua Phi from meeting a US diplomat in Ho Chi Minh City in July 2025. USCIRF is a US government body, and Vietnam disputes it. On March 19, 2026, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Pham Thu Hang firmly

rejected its annual recommendation as unobjective and inaccurate, and said no citizen faces discrimination for religion or belief.

The letter also says a Dallas County, Texas, district court ruled on August 16, 2023, that the 1997 Sect and its leader were a racketeering enterprise and ordered damages paid to two followers and a Dallas temple. That is the letter's account of the case and it could not be independently checked from court records for this document. The Vietnamese government and the recognized church describe the same institution as the lawful Holy See, operating under Vietnam's legally recognized religious bodies, and its public events are attended by state officials. Readers should know both descriptions exist. The evidence published by USCIRF and the State Department supports the claim that independent Caodaists have been harassed. Claims about the sect's founding purpose come mainly from its opponents.

Gender remains an open question. Cao Dai ordained women from its earliest years, an early and meaningful step, and its theology has a strong Divine Mother. But women can rise only as far as Cardinal, on the ground that yin may not rule over yang, and some of the marriage rules reflect a world that permitted a second wife for a childless first wife.

Numbers are unreliable and politically charged. Estimates run from about 1 million for a single church to several million for all branches, and some figures reflect aspiration or older counts. This document reports the source of each.

Finally, the popular image needs correcting. Graham Greene's narrator in The Quiet American dismissed the religion as the invention of a Cochin civil servant and a phony hierarchy, and travel writing has often kept that tone, presenting Cao Dai as a colorful curiosity in which Victor Hugo is a saint and everything is mixed together. The writer Paul La Farge saw no reason to think the early séances were a sham, and read the summoning of Hugo, a famous enemy of empire, as very likely a political act in a colony. Its followers have endured war, exile, state pressure, and the loss of their temples, and their theology is coherent on its own terms. Its critics are right to raise the record of its armies, and its followers are right to insist that it be read as a serious religion.

The Haligricity Lens

Cao Dai arrives at a conclusion very close to the premise of this whole library: that the traditions of the world are not rivals, and that a person can look across them and find one Way. That makes it an unusually close relative of what Haligricity is doing, and a useful warning as well. Cao Dai's experience shows what happens when a synthesis acquires a hierarchy, a property portfolio, and a claim to exclusive revelation. The oath to know only one Cao Dai religion sits uneasily beside the teaching that all religions are one. Haligricity's answer is to treat synthesis as a practice done by each person, and never as a jurisdiction.

The Three Treasures carry a clear Tetralty resonance. Flowers, wine, and tea stand for body, energy, and spirit, and the worshipper offers all three at once. The four daily offerings and the graded vegetarian path show how a large idea becomes a habit: the feeling of devotion is carried by a thought of God, spoken in prayer, and enacted by the hand placing a cup of tea on an altar at six in the morning. When any one of those is missing, the ritual goes hollow, and Cao Dai's own insistence on sincerity recognizes it.

Most of all, the Divine Eye offers a teaching worth keeping: the eyes are the master of the mind, and the mind is God. Whatever watches, in you, is not separate from what you are watching for.

Closing

At six o'clock tonight, the bell will ring at Tay Ninh, and rows of people in white will walk into a long pink nave beneath a painted sky. Tea will go on the altar. Somewhere in California, somewhere in Phnom Penh, someone else will light five sticks of incense in two rows in a quiet corner of a family home.

Some of those people are cut off from the temples their grandparents built, and they keep their devotion anyway. A clerk in a colonial office once looked up and saw an eye. It is still open. You are the current.